

Masturi Season

Tanabata

It started, like many things on the island, quietly. I didn't notice it at first. Just small changes. People cleaning, moving with a certain intention. Graves being tended to. Paths cleared. Not in a symbolic way, but in a very real one, as if someone was expected to arrive, and you didn't want them to trip on the way in.

Later, Miki-san explained it to me. A story about two lovers separated by a river of stars. They were only allowed to meet once a year, if they had both done their part, if they had worked enough, if the sky allowed it.

A bridge of birds would form.

Or not.

It stayed with me longer than I expected.

Tanabata didn't feel romantic to me. It felt conditional. It made me think about my past relationship, in which I consistently lost my way onto it. Which is ironically why I decided to flee and end up here.

Obon

Then came Obon. The island changed rhythm. Not louder, not busier, just fuller. As if something invisible had taken up space between people.

Families gathered. Food appeared everywhere. Doors stayed open.

The idea was simple: the dead come back for a few days.

No one questioned it. No one dramatized it either. It wasn't mystical. It was practical.

They come. You welcome them. You spend time together. Then you help them leave.

I had seen something similar before, in Peru, during *Día de los Muertos*. Different colors, different smells, different sounds, but the same intention underneath.

The same refusal to let memory dissolve.

Memory, given structure.

And then, at night, you would hear it.

Eisa

At first, just distant drums. Then closer. Then suddenly, they were there, moving through the streets in a slow, deliberate procession.

Drums strapped to bodies. Movements both sharp and fluid. Voices rising, falling, repeating.

They weren't performing. They were guiding.

Someone told me the dances had once disappeared. Lost after the war. And then, somehow, brought back. Rebuilt. Relearned. Not exactly the same, but alive again.

There were roles within it. The ones carrying the rhythm deep in their shoulders. The ones leading the song with the *sanshin*. And the ones with painted faces, half clowns, half conductors, quietly holding everything together without ever taking the center.

They stopped in front of houses. In front of newly opened places.

Always moving. Always drumming. Always dancing.

As if the sound itself was a path.

The tug-of-war - Oonahiki

And then, weeks later, everything shifted.

From the past to the future.

One moment I was riding through the narrow, hilly roads of the village, the next I was being pulled into something I didn't fully understand. Miki-san brought to the fields to meet with the other women of the village.

Rice straw, laid out in piles. Dry, golden, deceptively light. We began twisting it, braiding it, tightening it. Over and over. Small strands becoming larger ones, larger ones becoming something thicker, heavier, patterns repeating inside patterns, like fractals you could hold in your hands.

This wasn't just a rope.

It was the *Ufunaa*.

Two sides of the island working in parallel. Not against each other, not yet. The East and the West. Fishermen and farmers. Sea and land, in a quiet kind of balance.

The rope itself came in two parts. One with a loop. The other with a thick, straight head. Later, they would be joined, locked together with a massive wooden pin. People laughed about it, of course. No one missed the implication.

But before that, there was work. Hours of it.

Hands moving without much talking. Older hands correcting younger ones. A rhythm that didn't need explaining.

At that point, I thought I was just there to watch.

I was wrong.

Morino-san shouted at me. Sharp, direct. No room for hesitation. A *tenugui* was shoved into my hands, the mark of the West, tied tight across my forehead before I could even react.

Then I was in.

Forty people, maybe more. The rope was impossibly heavy. It didn't feel like something meant to be moved.

We carried it to the center of the village.

The two sides met. The ropes were joined. The wooden pin dropped through. A moment of pause.

Then tension.

Across from me stood the East. At the front, a man they called Jumbo; easily the largest man I had seen in Japan, built like the kind of weight that doesn't get moved, only resisted.

Behind him, Michael, the only other foreigner on the island. An English teacher from the US. We had spent weeks sharing quiet routines, small conversations, the kind that build familiarity without effort.

Now we were on rivals. He looked at me and smiled.

“Ready?” Not really. But it didn’t matter. The signal came.

At first, nothing moved. Then a shift. The East pulled hard. We gave ground. Just a little.

Then something changed behind me. A sound. A rhythm. Voices rising together.

“Ousss!”

We pulled... Not as individuals, but as something else entirely.

I had never pulled that hard in my life.

And suddenly, it was over.

The rope moved. The East collapsed forward.

Afterwards, everything softened again. Laughter. Hands on shoulders. Beers appearing from nowhere. Stories from previous years, told like they had just happened.

Everyone “otsukaresamed” everyone else.

We dropped into that resting squat, heels flat on the ground, bodies folded low, close to the earth, breathing slowly again.

The same people who had been straining seconds before were now completely at ease.

The future; a good harvest, which I didn’t know I would actually be part of..
